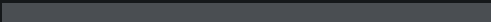


THE 5 LEVELS OF AI

Everybody says you should use AI. Nobody says what that means. **This is the plain English version.** Five levels. Find yours in ten minutes. Then find out what staying there is costing you.

- 05  RUNNING A TEAM
- 04  CHAINING
- 03  BUILDING · THE MONEY IS HERE
- 02  WORKING TOGETHER
- 01  CHATTING · YOU ARE HERE

START HERE

FIVE LEVELS, ONE AT A TIME

Most AI guides hand you twenty apps. The app was never the hard part.

Here are five levels. Each answers one question: **how much of the work happens while you are not watching?**

HOW TO USE THIS

Find the level you are really on, not the one you wish you were on. Then look at the next one up.

This guide is the map. What it cannot give you is **which step you are on, and what it is worth to take the next one**. That part is different for every business.

Go one level at a time. People who jump from Level 1 to Level 4 land on a mess and a bill.

THE FIVE LEVELS

01



CHATTING

You ask. It answers. A better Google.

02



WORKING TOGETHER

You hand it real work. It does the first draft.

03



BUILDING

It makes you a small tool you could never have paid for.

BEST PAYOFF • ALMOST NOBODY IS HERE

04



CHAINING

A whole job runs across your systems from start to end.

05



RUNNING A TEAM

One helper per job, plus a boss helper that runs them in order.

THE SHORT VERSION

Most businesses are on Level 1. Almost nobody is on Level 3, the one that pays. Read on and you know your level. Call us and you know your number.

LEVEL 01

CHATTING

A better Google.

You open a chat box. You type a question. You get an answer. No more reading five websites to find one fact.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- “Write a nice email telling a customer their part is late.”
- “What is a certificate of insurance, and why does my customer want one?”
- “What is a fair late fee to put on my bills?”

WHAT YOU GET OUT OF IT

Real time saved. Maybe half an hour a day, for the one person using it. But here is the catch. All of it lives in one person's head and one browser tab. Your business did not change. Nothing got built. If that person quits tomorrow, nothing is lost, because nothing was made.

HOW YOU KNOW YOU ARE READY TO MOVE UP

You keep typing the same stuff over and over. Your prices. Your services. How you talk to customers. Every morning you explain your own business to it from scratch.

THE SIGNAL

If you are answering the same basic questions every day, or repeating the same basic tasks, you have outgrown Level 1.

APPS

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini. Free, or about \$20 a month per person.

SETUP

Ten minutes.

WATCH OUT

Your people pasting customer info into free personal accounts. Most common danger at a small business right now. Also the easiest to fix.

WHAT WE FIND

Almost every time we look, customer info is sitting in somebody's personal account. Finding yours takes one call.

LEVEL 02

WORKING TOGETHER

You hand over real work.

On Level 1 you ask questions. On Level 2 you hand over jobs, with your real files and your real numbers.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Drop in a 40 page contract. Get back the five parts that could hurt you.
- Give it last quarter's numbers. Ask which part of the business loses money.
- Show it your five best bids. Have it write the sixth, in your words.

WHAT CHANGES

You never start with a blank page again. For a one person business that is three bids a week turning into eight.

And it remembers you now. Save your business once, your prices, your voice, your files, and it keeps all of it. Hook it up to your email and documents. Put it on a schedule so the work is waiting for you.

WHERE IT STILL STOPS

The work comes back to you. It writes the reply, you send it. It spots the problem, you go fix it.

THE LIMIT

Level 2 hands you finished thinking. It does not finish the job. Nothing moves through the rest of your business without a person carrying it there.

APPS

Paid plans, so you can save your setup, upload files, and schedule work.

SETUP

A few hours to write your business down. You only do it once.

WATCH OUT

It can be wrong and still sound sure of itself. Somebody has to check the work.

WHAT WE FIND

There is a short list of things worth writing down once. Most owners guess wrong on the first three. Ask us which three are yours.



BUILDING

It makes you the tool.

Nobody tells small business owners about this level. It is the one that pays the best.

Say you wanted a small tool. A price calculator. A job tracker. One screen pulling three spreadsheets into one number. You used to have two choices: pay a programmer a lot, or do without.

That is over. Describe the tool in plain words and you get one. Not fancy software. Small, boring software that does one thing your business needs.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- A price calculator with your real rules in it, so anyone can quote without calling you.
- A form for new jobs that routes each one to the right person.
- One screen showing money in and money out for the week.
- A tool that reads your bills and flags overcharges.

WHY THIS LEVEL IS THE BIG ONE

Levels 1 and 2 make you faster. **Level 3 makes your business need you less.** Your pricing rules used to live in your head. Now they live in a tool anyone can use. That is what lets you hire, take a week off, and one day sell.

THE HONEST WARNING

Anyone can now build something that works the first time. Far fewer can build something that keeps working. Build small. And have somebody who knows computers check anything that touches customer info or money before you turn it on.

APPS

Claude or ChatGPT. Both can build a working tool and publish it inside their own app.

SETUP

Days per tool. Not months.

WATCH OUT

Safety and upkeep. Six half broken tools and nobody in charge of them.

THE CATCH

Picking the right first tool is the whole game. Pick wrong and you burn a month. A PDF cannot make that pick.

LEVEL 04

CHAINING

The whole job runs by itself.

Level 2 hands the work back to you. Level 4 finishes it. Something happens, and the whole job runs across your systems from start to end. You see the result, not the steps.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- A customer fills out your form. The chain looks them up, writes a reply, drops it in your inbox ready to send, and saves them to your list.
- A bill lands in your email. It gets read, sorted, checked against what you agreed to pay, and entered in your books. Anything odd comes to you.
- A job finishes. The customer gets a thank you. Three days later they get asked for a review. The warranty date gets saved.

WHAT CHANGES

This is the first level that removes a whole job, instead of making a person faster at it.

It is also the first level where things break while nobody is looking. Somebody has to notice when the chain quietly stops working on a Tuesday.

THE STEP PEOPLE SKIP

You cannot automate a job you have never written down. If three people do the same job three different ways, automating it just picks one of those ways at random and locks it in forever.

THE HIDDEN WIN

Level 4 forces you to finally decide how your business actually runs. For a lot of owners that turns out to be worth more than the automation was.

APPS

Zapier, Make, n8n, plus hookups to the systems you already use.

SETUP

A few weeks per chain, including testing.

WATCH OUT

It breaks quietly. Somebody has to own it and keep an eye on it.

WHAT WE FIND

Nearly every business has one job that should be chained first. It is almost never the one the owner names. We can usually spot yours in one call.

LEVEL 05

RUNNING A TEAM

One helper per job. One boss helper to run them.

Level 4 chains steps. Level 5 builds helpers. You train one helper to be very good at one job, then a boss helper that calls them in order and checks each one worked.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE: ONE SOCIAL POST

- **Topic picker.** Finds what is trending and fits your business.
- **Writer.** Drafts it several ways, always in your voice.
- **Editor.** Reads the drafts, picks the best one.
- **Image maker.** Makes or picks the picture.
- **Poster.** Sends it to the right place.

Then one more helper called “Make a social post.” It runs all five in order and checks each step worked before starting the next. A whole post becomes one instruction.

WHY THIS IS WORTH THE WORK

Each helper is a part you keep. You stop doing one off tasks and start building parts that add up. It needs clean records and someone checking on it. Everyone getting value here did Levels 3 and 4 first.

IF YOU ARE ON LEVEL 1

This is not your next move. It is the move after the two you have not made yet.

APPS

Claude or ChatGPT, using saved skills and projects.

SETUP

Ongoing. You build one helper at a time and keep them.

WATCH OUT

The biggest risk of all five levels. If it can act on its own, it needs limits and a person watching.

BEFORE YOU TRY

Most businesses are not ready for this yet. When you are, this is the work we call Embed: helpers in every department, with a policy behind them.

TWO MINUTES

SO WHERE ARE YOU?

Be honest. The question is not “has anyone here ever tried it once.” The question is “is this how we work on a normal Tuesday.”

- ☐ 01 Someone here uses an AI chat box most days instead of searching the web.
- ☐ 02 We hand it real work, our files and our paperwork, and we use what comes back.
- ☐ 03 There is at least one tool running in this business that AI helped us build.
- ☐ 04 There is at least one job that finishes without anybody pressing go.
- ☐ 05 We have built helpers for single jobs, and something that runs them in order.

HOW TO SCORE IT

Your real level is the highest box you checked where every box below it is checked too. Skipped levels are why most of these projects quietly die.

WHAT MOVING UP IS USUALLY WORTH

For a business with 5 to 50 people, going from Level 1 to Level 3 usually saves **five to fifteen hours a week** across the team. Your number will not be that number. It depends on your jobs and your people.

But the bigger win is this: what used to live in people's heads now lives in tools your business owns. That is the part that makes a business worth something.

THE MISSING PIECE

This page tells you your level. It does not tell you what staying there costs every month. That is the first thing we work out on a call, and it is usually bigger than owners expect.

CHECKED 0 TO 1 Start at Level 2. You are leaving easy time on the table.

CHECKED 2 Level 3 is your move, the biggest one in this guide.

CHECKED 3+ You are ahead of nearly everyone. Now it needs looking after.

THE NEXT STEP

YOU KNOW YOUR LEVEL. NOW GET YOUR NUMBER.

Everything here you can do on your own, and you should start today. What a guide cannot give you is which move is yours and what it is worth. That takes one free 20 minute call.

START THESE THREE YOURSELF, TODAY

- **Find out where your info is going.** Ask your team which AI apps they use and on what accounts. Most owners are surprised.
- **Pick the thing that annoys you every week.** Not the biggest problem. The one that keeps coming back.
- **Write down how one job gets done.** One page. What you would hand a new hire.

All three are free and they work. They are also the easy part.

WHAT A GUIDE CANNOT TELL YOU: THE AUDIT

- **Your real level,** and the one thing holding you at it. It is rarely what the owner guesses.
- **What staying there costs you per month.** A real number for your business, not an average.
- **Your first build.** The one tool worth making first, and the ones to skip.
- **Where your customer info is sitting right now.** We have never looked and found nothing.
- A written plan you keep either way. Flat fee, agreed up front. **And that fee comes straight off your build if you go ahead within 30 days.**

BUILD

We make the tool. We write down how it works and hand it over. No black boxes.

EMBED

We stay on and look after the AI side of your business, like we would a network.

TWENTY MINUTES. BRING YOUR LEVEL.

Tell us the number you checked on the last page. We will tell you what we usually find at that level, and what it costs businesses like yours. Free, whether or not you hire us.

(626) 838-2862

max@footholdsystems.com

footholdsystems.com